Fantastic Mr. Fox

By Roald Dahl

Suggested Roles: ***ACTOR 1:*** *Narrator 1, Mr. Fox, Boggis, Bean, Rat*
ACTOR 2: *Narrator 2, Bunce, Mrs. Fox, Badger*

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

NARRATOR 2: **(Pgs 1-4)** Down in the valley there were three farms. The owners were rich, nasty men: Farmer Boggis, Farmer Bunce and Farmer Bean.

NARRATOR 1: Boggis was an enormously fat chicken farmer. *(Actor 1 mimes Boggis)* He ate three boiled chickens smothered with dumplings every day for breakfast, lunch and supper.

NARRATOR 2: Bunce was a duck-and-goose farmer. *(Actor 2 mimes Bunce)* He was a pot-bellied dwarf. His food was doughnuts and goose livers. He mashed the livers into a disgusting paste and then stuffed the paste into the doughnuts.

NARRATOR 1: Bean was a turkey-and-apple farmer. *(Actor 1 mimes Bean)* He never ate any food at all. Instead, he drank gallons of strong cider which he made from the apples in his orchard. He was as thin as a pencil and the cleverest of them all.

INTRODUCTION

Someone's been stealing from the three meanest farmers around, and they know the identity of the thief—it's Fantastic Mr. Fox! Working alone they could never catch him; but now fat Boggis, squat Bunce, and skinny Bean have joined forces, and they have Mr. Fox and his family surrounded. What they don't know is that they're not dealing with just any fox—Mr. Fox would rather die than surrender. Only the most fantastic plan can save him now.

Nobody outfoxes the . . . Fantastic Mr. Fox by Roald Dahl

NARRATOR 2: **(Pgs 7-9)** On a hill above the valley lived Mr. and Mrs. Fox and their four small foxes. Every evening as soon as it got dark Mr. Fox would say . . .

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MR. FOX: Well, what shall it be this time? A plump chicken from Boggis? A duck or a goose from Bunce? Or a nice turkey from Bean?

NARRATOR 2: And Mr. Fox would creep down into the valley in the darkness of the night and help himself.

BOGGIS: Dang and blast that lousy beast!

BUNCE: I'd like to rip his guts out!

BOGGIS: How on earth can we catch the blighter?

BEAN: *(picking his nose delicately)* I have a plan. Tomorrow night we will all hide just outside the hole where the fox lives. . . wait there until he comes out. Then. . . *(mimes a shotgun) Bang! Bang-bang-bang!*

MR. FOX: **(Pg 10-14)** What shall it be tonight?

MRS. FOX: Bring us two fat ducks, if you please. One for you and me, and one for the children. Just don't get careless. You know they'll be waiting for you, all three of them.

MR. FOX: Don't you worry about me. I'll see you later.

NARRATOR 2: But Mr. Fox would not have been quite so cocky had he known the three farmers were waiting just outside the entrance to the hole, each one crouching behind a tree with his gun loaded.

MR. FOX: *(creeping to the mouth of his hole, he pokes his face out and sniffs)*

BEAN: *(mimes a shotgun) Bang-bang! Bangbang! Bang-bang! (to the others)* Did we get him? *(he finds the remains of a fox's tail and picks it up, disappointed)* We got the tail but we missed the fox.

BUNCE: He won't be poking out again in a hurry.

BEAN: It'll take three days at least before he gets hungry enough to come out again. I'm not sitting around here waiting for that. Let's dig him out!

MR. FOX: **(Pg 15-19)** *(Glumly while Mrs. Fox tends to his tail)* It will never grow again. I shall be tail-less for the rest of my life. I suppose I'm lucky to be alive at all. And now they've found our hole, we're going to have to move out as soon as possible. We'll never get any peace if we. . . What was *that? (turns his head sharply and listens)*

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NARRATOR 2: Suddenly there was an especially loud crunch above their heads and the sharp end of a shovel came right through the ceiling.

MR. FOX: Come on! There's not a moment to lose! *(beginning to dig)* Nobody in the world can dig as quick as a fox! Go downwards! We've got to go deep! *(frantic digging)*

MRS. FOX: *(panting for breath; to their children)* I should like you to know that if it wasn't for your father we should all be dead by now. Your father is a fantastic fox.

BOGGIS: **(Pg 20-22)** *(exhausted from digging)* Dang and blast! Whose rotten idea was this?

BEAN: *(angrily)* Listen. I'm going to get that fox! I'm not giving in till I've strung him up over my front porch, dead as a dumpling! What we need is machines . . . *mechanical* shovels!

NARRATOR 2: Soon, two enormous caterpillar tractors came clanking into the wood. They were murderous, brutal-looking monsters. Now there began a desperate race, the machines against the foxes.

BUNCE: **(Pg 27)** Hey there, Mr. Fox! We're coming to get you now!

MR. FOX: **(Pg 23)** Tractors! And *mechanical* shovels! Dig for your lives! *Dig, dig, dig!*

BOGGIS: **(Pg 27)** You've had your last chicken! You'll never come prowling around *my* farm again!

NARRATOR 2: **(Pg 29)** At six o'clock in the evening. Bean switched off his tractor and climbed down from the driver's seat. Bunce did the same. Both men had had enough. **(Pg 28)** The hole was like the crater of a volcano.

BOGGIS: **(Pg 29-30)** Dang and blast that filthy stinking fox! What the heck do we do now?

BEAN: There's only one thing to do. We starve him out. We camp here day and night watching the hole. He'll come out in the end. He'll have to.

NARRATOR 2: **(Pg 34-36)** For three days and three nights this waiting-game went on. Down in the tunnel the foxes were slowly but surely starving to death.

MR. FOX: *(deep in the new tunnel)* I've just had an idea. It means more digging.

NARRATOR 2: **(Pg 38-39)** For a long, long time Mr. Fox and the children kept on digging. Slowly, wearily, the foxes began to slope the tunnel up towards the surface.

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MR. FOX: (Pg 40) *(cautiously poking his head up through the gap; he shrieks in excitement)* I've done it! I've done it *(pulls himself up though the gap and starts dancing with joy)* Come up and see where you are! Hallelujah! Hooray! Hooray! Boggis's Chicken House Number One! Isn't that fantastic!

NARRATOR 2: Mr. Fox chose three of the plumpest hens, and with a clever flick of his jaws he killed them instantly.

BADGER: (Pg 46-47) *(a deep voice from the shadows)* Who goes there?

MR. FOX: Badger!

BADGER: Foxy! Haven't you *heard* what's happening up on the hill? It's chaos! Half the wood has disappeared and there are men with guns! What on earth are we going to do, Foxy? None of us can get out, even at night! I think we're finished!

MR. FOX: Who is we?

BADGER: All us diggers. Me and Mole and Rabbit and all our wives and children. Even Weasel, who can usually sneak out of the tightest spots, is right now hiding down my hole with Mrs. Weasel and six kids.

MR. FOX: (Pg 42) *handing the hens to one of the children)* Run back with these to your mother. Tell her to prepare a feast. [We'll] be along in a jiffy, as soon as we have made a few other little arrangements. **(Pg 49)** *(to Badger)* You have come just at the right moment, my dear Badger. You can help us dig.

BADGER: (Pg 58-59) *(while they are digging)* Doesn't this worry you just a tiny bit, Foxy? All this. . . this *stealing*.

MR. FOX: *(looks at Badger as if he is crazy)* My dear old furry frump. do you know anyone in the *whole world* who wouldn't swipe a few chickens if his children were starving to death? **(Pg 60-61)** We shall simply take a little food here and there to keep us and our families alive. Right?

NARRATOR 2: Five minutes later, Badger's front paws hit against something flat and hard. It was a wall. But it was built of bricks, not stones. Mr. Fox saw that the cement between the bricks was old and crumbly *(Mr. Fox and Badger begin loosening bricks)*

RAT: Go away! You can't come in here! It's private!

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BADGER: Good Lord! It's Rat! **(Pg 74)** All rats have bad manners. I've never met a polite rat yet.

MR. FOX: **(Pg 62)** *(smiling widely and speaking softly)* My dear Rat, I am a hungry fellow and if you don't hop it quickly I shall eat-you-up-in-one-gulp!*(Mr. Fox and Badger break down the wall and climb through)* **(Pg 64-66)** Bean's Secret Cider Cellar. It will make the feast into a banquet!

BADGER: Cider is especially good for Badgers. We take it as medicine -- one large glass three times a day. *(drinks deeply)* Oh, Foxy, it's like drinking sunbeams and rainbows!

RAT: You're poaching! Put that down at once! There'll be none left for me! If you great clumsy brutes come messing about in here, we'll all be caught!

NARRATOR 1: **(Pg 71)** Mr. Fox and Badger ran across the cellar clutching a gallon jar each.

RAT: Thieves! Robbers! Bandits! Burglars!

NARRATOR 2: **(Pg 72-73)** Along the tunnel they flew. . . past Boggis's Chicken House Number One and then up the long home stretch towards the place where they knew Mrs. Fox would be waiting.

NARRATOR 1: **(Pg 74-75)** They rounded the final corner and burst in upon the most wonderful sight they had ever seen. The feast was just beginning. A large dining-room had been hollowed out of the earth, and in the middle of it, seated around a huge table, were no less than twenty-nine animals.

NARRATOR 1: Foxes and badgers

NARRATOR 2: Moles and rabbits

TOGETHER: Weasels!

NARRATOR 1: **(Pg 76-77)** You must remember no one had eaten a thing for several days. They were ravenous. So for a while there there was only the sound of crunching and chewing as the animals attacked the succulent food. *(chewing, burping, assorted other noises)* At last, Badger stood up.

BADGER: *(raising his glass of cider)* A toast! To our dear friend who has saved our lives this day -- Mr. Fox.

TOGETHER: *(shouting)* To Mr. Fox! Long may he live!

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MRS. FOX: *(shyly)* I don't want to make a speech. I just want to say one thing: MY HUSBAND IS A FANTASTIC FOX.

TOGETHER: *(cheering and clapping)*

MR. FOX: **(Pg 78-81)** *(grinning hugely)* Thank you. But now, my friends, let us be serious. Let us think of tomorrow and the days after that. If we go out, we will be killed. Right?

TOGETHER: *(shouting)* Right!

MR.FOX: But who *wants* to go out, anyway? We are all diggers. We hate the outside. We only go out because we have to, to get food for our families. But now, my friends, we have a safe tunnel leading to the finest stores in the world! It means that none of us need ever go out into the open again! I invite you all to stay here with me forever.

TOGETHER: Forever!

MR. FOX: We will make an underground village, with streets and separate houses for Badgers and Moles and Rabbits and Weasels and Foxes. And every day we will eat like kings.

TOGETHER: *(cheering and clapping)*

NARRATOR 1: Outside the Fox's hole, Boggis and Bunce and Bean sat with their guns on their laps. It was beginning to rain. Water was trickling down the necks of the three men and into their shoes.

BOGGIS: *(miserably)* He won't stay down there much longer now.

NARRATOR 1: [And] they sat there by the hole, waiting for the fox to come out.

NARRATOR 2: So far as [we] know, they are still waiting.

BEAN: *(sneezes loudly)*

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AWARD HISTORY

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